THE CLIENT ACQUISITION PLAYBOOK

A Practical System for Finding Leads, Booking Calls & Winning Clients



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Sources

Statements of fact are supported by the references at the end of the book, with the date each source was checked. Web pages change; confirm current details before relying on them.

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Introduction

Most service businesses do not fail because the work is poor. They stall because the next client does not arrive on a schedule. Work comes in bursts, from a referral here and a lucky message there, and between those bursts the owner is nervous and unfocused.

This book gives you a complete chain from a stranger to a signed client: choose a niche, define the ideal customer, shape an offer, build proof, find leads, contact them honestly, hold a useful call, qualify, propose, price, follow up and turn the whole thing into a weekly routine. Nothing in it needs paid software. A spreadsheet and an inbox are enough.

Who it is for: freelancers, independent consultants, small agencies and other service businesses that sell expertise to other businesses (and in some cases to individuals). It assumes you can already do the work. It does not teach the work itself.

What is inside:

- 15 chapters in the order a client moves through your pipeline, each ending with common mistakes and fixes.
- 20 outreach templates, 10 follow up templates, 10 discovery call scripts and 5 proposal frameworks. Every one has a when to use it note, instructions and a fully filled example for a fictional business.
- An ideal customer profile worksheet, a client qualification worksheet with a scoring method, a lead tracking system, a CRM spreadsheet structure with formulas, and a 30 day

roadmap.
- An appendix on ethics, consent, anti spam rules and platform rules, a templates index and a glossary.

What it does not do:

- It does not promise income, reply rates or a number of clients. Your results depend on your market, your offer, your skill and your consistency. Where the book uses numbers, they are either arithmetic you can check or clearly labelled illustrations.
- It does not recommend scraping, mass automation or any tactic that breaks a platform's rules.
- It is not legal, tax or financial advice. Rules on marketing messages differ by country. Appendix A points you to the official regulator pages.

How to use it: read Chapters 1 to 5 once, in order, and complete the worksheets. These decide who you target and what you say. Then treat Chapters 6 to 14 as a reference you return to while working, and use Chapter 15 to set a weekly routine. All fictional business names and people in the examples are invented. Replace every bracketed item such as [first name] with real, specific detail before you send anything.

How this book was researched (2026-11-07): I reviewed the structure of competing client acquisition guides on Gumroad, which are mostly narrow template packs or cold email only guides, and wrote this book to cover the full chain instead. I read search result summaries of forum threads and blogs where freelancers describe problems (no replies to cold messages, silence after a proposal) and wrote chapters to address them; these are anecdotal and I treat them that way. For compliance statements I opened the US FTC CAN-SPAM guide, the European Commission data protection page and LinkedIn's official help pages. The UK ICO pages returned an access error when I tried to open them, so the book describes the UK rules only in general

terms and sends you to the ICO to read them yourself. The pricing arithmetic and the spreadsheet formulas were run and checked; Appendix B says how.

CHAPTER 1

Understanding client acquisition

What client acquisition is

Client acquisition is the repeatable process of turning people who have never heard of you into people who pay you. It has six stages, and every chapter of this book belongs to one of them:

Stage	Question it answers	Chapters
Positioning	Who do I serve and what do I sell?	2, 3, 4, 5
Lead generation	Who might need this?	6, 9
Outreach	How do I start a conversation?	7, 8
Conversation	Is there a real problem and budget?	10, 11
Closing	How do we agree terms?	12, 13
Follow up and system	How do I stop leads from dying and repeat this?	14, 15

Marketing creates awareness, sales converts a specific person. A freelancer does both, usually in the same week, which is why a written process matters. Without one, you do what feels comfortable (updating a portfolio) instead of what moves a deal (sending three messages).

The pipeline is arithmetic

A pipeline is a chain of steps, and each step loses people. The loss at each step is a conversion rate. Here is an illustration with invented numbers, not a benchmark:

```
Contacted        100 people
Replied           12   (12 / 100 = 12%)
Call held          5   (5 / 12  = 41.7%)
Proposal sent      3   (3 / 5   = 60%)
Won                1   (1 / 3   = 33.3%)
Overall: 1 / 100 = 1%
```

Do not treat these rates as typical. Yours will differ, and the point is the method: measure each step, find the weakest one, and fix that step first. If replies are 12% but calls held are low, your offer to meet is the problem. If calls are held but proposals die, your qualification or proposal is the problem. Improving the wrong step wastes weeks.

Working backwards gives you a volume target. If your own tracked overall rate turns out to be 1%, you need 300 contacts for 3 wins (3 / 0.01 = 300). If you only reach 20 qualified contacts a week, the arithmetic tells you the timeline honestly, and tells you whether to improve the rate or the volume.

The four assets every system needs

1. **A defined target:** a narrow type of buyer you can name and find (Chapters 2 and 3).
2. **A clear offer:** what you deliver, for whom, by when, in plain words (Chapter 4).
3. **Proof:** evidence you can do it, even if small (Chapter 5).
4. **A tracked process:** a list of people and the next action for each (Chapter 14 and Appendix B).

If one is missing, the rest underperform. A perfect cold email sent to the wrong people with a vague offer and no proof will not work.

Warm, cold and inbound

- **Warm:** people who know you. Past clients, colleagues, referrals. Highest trust, limited quantity.
- **Cold:** people who do not know you. Unlimited quantity, lowest trust, needs relevance and restraint.
- **Inbound:** people who found you. Highest intent, depends on visibility built over time (Chapter 9).

Start with warm, run cold at a steady small volume, and build inbound slowly in the background. Relying on only one makes income swing.

Common mistakes and fixes

Mistake: Treating acquisition as something to do when work runs out.
Fix: Give it a fixed weekly slot, even when fully booked. Pipelines take weeks to respond.

Mistake: Changing the message every few days.
Fix: Send at least 30 contacts with one version before judging it.

Mistake: Tracking only wins.
Fix: Record every stage so you can see where people drop out.

CHAPTER 2

Finding profitable customer niches

Why a niche helps

A niche is a group of buyers who share a problem you can solve. "I do marketing" forces every prospect to work out whether you are relevant. "I run email onboarding sequences for subscription software companies" answers the question before it is asked. A niche also makes lead lists, proof and messages reusable.

A niche is not forever. It is a working hypothesis you test for a few months.

Four filters

Score each candidate niche from 1 (weak) to 5 (strong) on these filters:

Filter	Question
Pain	Do they feel the problem now, and do they already spend time or money on it?
Budget	Can they pay your price without a committee approving it for months?
Access	Can you find named people and contact them honestly?
Fit	Do you have skills, proof or interest in this type of business?

Add the four scores. Anything under 12 out of 20 is a weak candidate. Two niches within two points of each other: pick the one with better access, because access decides how fast you can test.

A worked example (fictional)

Dana is a freelance bookkeeper. She scores three candidates:

Niche	Pain	Budget	Access	Fit	Total
Independent dental practices	4	4	3	2	13
Online course creators	3	3	4	3	13
Small architecture studios	4	4	4	4	16

Dana picks architecture studios because a previous employer was one (fit), studio owners are listed on public directories (access), and project based billing makes bookkeeping messy (pain).

How to find evidence, not guesses

- Look at 20 businesses in the niche. Do they mention the problem on their websites, job ads or social posts?
- Check whether competitors already serve the niche. Competitors are a sign of paid demand, not a reason to leave.
- Talk to five people in the niche before committing. Ask what is hardest this quarter, and what they have tried.
- Watch for niches where the buyer is the user. Buyers who are also the person suffering decide faster.

Do not rely on a claim that a niche "pays well" unless you can see actual prices on competitors' public pages or from your own quotes. This book does not quote market rates because they vary too widely to state honestly.

Common mistakes and fixes

Mistake: Choosing a niche because it sounds lucrative.
Fix: Choose where pain, access and fit are all at least 3.

Mistake: Going so narrow that there are fewer than 100 reachable companies.
Fix: Count the reachable names. If fewer than 100, widen by region or adjacent type.

Mistake: Switching niches after two weeks.
Fix: Commit to 60 days or 100 contacts, then review.

CHAPTER 3

Understanding ideal customers

From niche to person

A niche is a group. An ideal customer is a specific profile inside it: the company type, the person who decides, the trigger that makes them act, and the reasons they would say no. Writing it down lets you filter lists, personalise messages and qualify calls against criteria instead of mood.

Ideal customer profile worksheet

Copy this and fill it in for your niche. Complete every line; an empty line shows a decision you have not made.

```
IDEAL CUSTOMER PROFILE (ICP)

1. Niche in one sentence:
2. Company type and size (people, revenue band, locations):
3. Buyer role (who signs or pays):
4. Day to day contact (who you will talk to):
5. The problem, in their words:
6. What it costs them now (time, money, risk):
7. Triggers (events that make this urgent):
8. What they have already tried:
9. Budget range they can approve alone:
10. Where to find them (directories, communities, events):
11. Disqualifiers (traits that mean no):
12. Proof they would trust (case, number, referral):
```

```
13. Typical objections:
14. How I will contact them (channels):
```

Filled example (fictional)

```
1. Niche: Small architecture studios in the UK doing residential
work.
2. Company: 3 to 15 staff, owner led, one or two offices.
3. Buyer: Studio director or practice manager.
4. Contact: Same person.
5. Problem: "I never know which projects are making money."
6. Cost: Director spends about a day a month on invoices;
   late invoices delay cash.
7. Triggers: New hire, new project stage billing, year end,
   tax deadline, bank asking for accounts.
8. Tried: Spreadsheet, generic accountant, accounting software.
9. Budget: Can approve a monthly fee alone, not above
   a project sized sum without a partner.
10. Find: RIBA style directories, LinkedIn, local business
groups.
11. Disqualifiers: Wants lowest price only; no software in use
   and refuses any; owes unfiled accounts they will not share.
12. Proof: Two pilot studios, a before and after invoice
   timeline.
13. Objections: "My accountant does this." "We are too small."
14. Channels: Warm intros, email, LinkedIn note.
```

Triggers beat demographics

Two companies of the same size differ in readiness. A trigger is an observable event: a hire, a funding announcement, a new product page, a bad review, a job ad for the role you could replace, a website that has not changed in years. Triggers let your first line be about them, not you, and they explain why you are writing now.

Use buying committees honestly

In small firms the owner decides. In larger ones, three roles appear: the person with the problem, the person with the budget, and the person who can say no (legal, IT, finance). Ask early who else will be involved

(Chapter 11).

Common mistakes and fixes

Mistake: Describing the customer as "any business that needs growth".
Fix: Name company type, size and trigger. If you cannot, you cannot find them.

Mistake: Writing the problem in your jargon.
Fix: Use the words buyers use in reviews, forum posts and calls. Update line 5 after every call.

Mistake: No disqualifiers.
Fix: Write three. They protect your time and your margin.

CHAPTER 4

Creating attractive service offers

What an offer is

An offer is a specific result, for a specific buyer, in a defined scope, time and price structure. A skill is not an offer. "Copywriting" is a skill. "A four email onboarding sequence for new subscribers, delivered in 10 working days with one revision round" is an offer.

Seven parts of a clear offer

1. **Who it is for:** the ICP in one phrase.
2. **The problem:** in their words.
3. **The outcome:** what changes, stated in measurable or observable terms you can influence.
4. **What is included:** deliverables and what is not.
5. **Timeline:** start, key dates, finish.
6. **Price structure:** fixed, monthly or phased (Chapter 13).
7. **Risk reducer:** something honest that lowers the buyer's fear, such as a paid first phase, a clear exit point, or a defined revision round. Avoid guarantees you cannot control.

Offer statement template

```
I help [buyer] with [problem] by [method], so that
[outcome]. It takes [timeline] and includes [deliverables].
```

```
It is not for [disqualifier].
```

Filled example (fictional)

```
I help small architecture studios with late invoicing by
setting up stage based billing and a monthly bookkeeping
routine, so that the director can see project profit
in one report. It takes 3 weeks to set up and then runs
monthly. It includes software setup, a project report
template and a monthly close. It is not for studios
that do not want to use accounting software.
```

Productise to reduce friction

A productised service has a fixed scope and price. Buyers understand it faster and you quote faster. Offer three levels where it makes sense:

Level	Idea	Example
Starter	Diagnose or set up	Two week billing audit
Core	Do the main work	Setup plus monthly routine
Ongoing	Maintain and improve	Monthly retainer with reporting

The starter level is useful in outreach because it is a small first yes. Do not make it so cheap that it attracts the wrong buyers or loses money.

Test the offer in a conversation

Say the offer aloud to three people in your niche. If they ask "so what do you actually do?", the offer is unclear. If they ask "how much and when can you start?", it is working.

Common mistakes and fixes

Mistake: Listing every service you can do.
Fix: Lead with one core offer. Keep other services for later conversations.

Mistake: Selling hours.
Fix: Sell a result and scope, then price using Chapter 13.

Mistake: Hidden scope.
Fix: Write what is excluded. Most disputes start in the gaps.

CHAPTER 5

Building portfolios and credibility

What buyers need to see

A cold prospect asks three silent questions: Is this person real? Have they done this before? Will it work for me? Your proof must answer those within a minute of landing on your page or profile.

Proof ladder, from none to strong

1. **No clients yet:** do a small piece of work for yourself or a friendly business, label it honestly as a sample, and show your method.
2. **A few clients:** a short case note: situation, what you did, what changed.
3. **Permission to name:** logo or named testimonial with written consent.
4. **Numbers:** only if you measured them and the client agrees to publish them.

Never invent clients, testimonials or numbers. If you need to anonymise, say so: "A UK architecture studio of 8 people."

Case note template

```
Client type: [size and sector, or name with permission]
Starting point: [the problem in one sentence]
```

```
What I did: [three bullet actions]
Result: [what changed, with a date or measure if real]
Time taken: [weeks]
Quote: [only if written permission exists]
```

Filled example (illustrative, fictional)

```
Client type: Architecture studio, 8 people (fictional).
Starting point: Invoices went out up to three weeks late.
What I did: Moved to stage based billing, set a weekly
invoice day, built a project profit report.
Result: Invoice delay in the sample month fell from 21 days
to 4 days (fictional figures for illustration).
Time taken: 3 weeks setup.
```

Minimum credible presence

- A one page site or document with your offer, ICP, two proof items and a booking or contact method.
- A LinkedIn profile whose headline names the buyer and the result, not a job title alone.
- Contact details that match across places.
- A short "how I work" section: steps and timings.

Getting testimonials

Ask within a week of delivering, while the result is fresh. Make it easy:

```
Subject: Two quick questions about our project

Hi [name], glad the [deliverable] is working for you.
Could you answer two questions in a sentence or two?
1) What was the situation before we started?
2) What is different now?
May I quote your answers on my site with your name and
company? If you prefer to stay anonymous, just say so.
```

Keep the written reply as your record of consent.

Common mistakes and fixes

Mistake: A portfolio of work unrelated to your target buyer.
Fix: Show 2 to 3 relevant pieces; remove the rest.

Mistake: Claims without evidence ("results driven").
Fix: Replace adjectives with what you did and what changed.

Mistake: Waiting to feel ready.
Fix: One honest sample for the exact niche beats five unrelated ones.

CHAPTER 6

Finding leads

What a lead is

A lead is a named person at a named business who fits your ideal customer profile and whom you can contact by an honest route. A company name alone is not a lead. A list of 500 unverified emails is not leads either.

Where to look, in order of quality

1. **Your own network:** past clients, former colleagues, people who have praised your work. Write 30 names this week.
2. **Referrals and introductions:** people connected to your past clients and peers who serve the same buyers without competing.
3. **Communities where your buyers ask questions:** professional forums, local business groups, industry newsletters with open comment sections. Observe the rules of each space.
4. **Public directories and associations:** member lists published for the purpose of being found.
5. **Trigger sources:** job ads, new product launches, funding or hiring news, new website pages, public reviews.
6. **Search and maps:** for local niches, search by service and area, then verify.

How to build a list of 50

Use one row per lead. Required fields: name, role, company, website, source, trigger, contact route, date found. If you cannot fill trigger and source, do not add the lead yet.

1. Define the filter from your ICP (size, region, type).
2. Collect 80 names from two sources.
3. Remove duplicates, competitors and anyone matching a disqualifier.
4. Find the right person: owner for small firms; head of the relevant function for larger ones.
5. Write one line of relevant observation per lead (the trigger). If you cannot write it in under two minutes, drop the lead.

Do not buy scraped lists, and do not use tools that harvest LinkedIn data. Appendix A explains why. Build smaller lists by hand; 50 well researched leads outperform 500 careless ones in the only way that matters here, they are safe to contact and easy to personalise.

Warm outreach templates

Warm messages work because the relationship does the heavy lifting. Keep them short, specific and easy to decline.

01. Referral ask to a happy client

When to use: within a month of a successful delivery, or at a natural review point.

Instructions: Name the result they got. Describe the kind of person you want to meet in one sentence. Offer to write the introduction text for them.

```
Subject: A small favour, if you are happy to

Hi Priya,
```

```
I am glad the new invoicing routine has cut your month end
to a single afternoon. I am looking for two or three more
architecture studios with 5 to 15 staff who have the same
late invoice problem.

Do you know a studio director who might find a short chat
useful? If so, I can write a two line note you can forward,
so it takes you under a minute. No pressure if no one comes
to mind.

Thanks again,
Tom
```

02. Warm introduction request to a mutual contact

When to use: you spotted a prospect who is connected to someone you know.

Instructions: Say why this person, what you would offer them, and make it easy for your contact to say no.

```
Subject: Could you introduce me to Ellis?

Hi Marcus,

I saw you are connected to Ellis Wong at Ridgeline Studio.
I help small studios fix late invoicing and have worked with
two similar firms. Would you be comfortable introducing us?

If it helps, here is a note you can forward:
"Ellis, meet Tom. He helped our studio with billing and I
thought a short chat could be useful. Up to you."

If you would rather not, I completely understand.

Tom
```

03. Forwardable introduction blurb

When to use: after someone agrees to introduce you.

Instructions: Write the message for the introducer to send, in their voice, with no hype and a clear next step.

```
Hi Ellis, I wanted to introduce Tom Reed. He set up our
stage billing last year and our invoices now go out weekly.
You mentioned slow cash flow last month, so I thought a
short chat might help. I have copied him here; reply if
you want to connect, ignore if not.
```

04. Past client reactivation

When to use: a client who finished more than 3 months ago and left on good terms.

Instructions: Do not start with a sales pitch. Refer to something specific from the project, give a reason to write now, and offer a low pressure option.

```
Subject: Checking in on the billing setup

Hi Sam,

It has been about eight months since we set up your project
billing. I was wondering how the monthly report is holding
up as you added two new staff.

If anything has drifted, I can do a 45 minute review and send
you a list of fixes, nothing more. If everything is fine,
I would still like to hear what is working.

Tom
```

05. Community reply that offers help

When to use: someone in a public community asks a question you can answer.

Instructions: Answer fully in public first. Mention your service only if the rules allow it, and never message someone privately unless they asked or the rules clearly permit it.

```
Reply on a public thread:

"For project based billing, the most common cause of late
invoices is that the invoice trigger is a date rather than a
stage. Try: 1) list your stages, 2) assign each a percentage,
3) set the invoice to be created when the stage is signed
off. If it helps, I can share the template I use in this
thread. (I do this for studios professionally, so feel free
to ask follow ups here.)"
```

06. Event or meeting follow up

When to use: within 48 hours of meeting someone at an event, webinar or call.

Instructions: Mention one real detail from the conversation. Offer one useful thing, not a pitch.

```
Subject: Good to meet you at Thursday's studio meetup

Hi Neha,

You mentioned that invoices wait until the whole project is
done. That is fixable without new software. I have a one page
guide to stage billing; shall I send it over?

Either way, good to meet you.

Tom
```

Common mistakes and fixes

Mistake: Hoarding names without an observation.
Fix: No trigger, no lead.

Mistake: Asking for referrals only when work is thin.
Fix: Ask after every successful delivery.

Mistake: Using a tool that scrapes profiles.
Fix: Research by hand; read Appendix A.

CHAPTER 7

Cold email prospecting

When cold email is appropriate

Cold email is a first message to someone who has not asked to hear from you. Done well, it is a short, relevant note to a person with a likely problem. Done badly, it is spam. Before sending, read Appendix A. In short: be honest about who you are, do not mislead in the subject line, include a way to opt out, honour opt outs, and know the rules in the country of your recipient. Rules differ and this is not legal advice.

Anatomy of a message

A good cold email has five parts, in 60 to 120 words:

1. **Subject:** plain, specific, matches the content.
2. **Opening line:** about them, based on something true and observable.
3. **Problem or idea:** one sentence on what you noticed or can help with.
4. **Proof:** one line of evidence.
5. **Small ask:** a yes or no question, not a 45 minute call.

A small ask lowers the effort needed to reply. Forum discussions among freelancers repeat the same observation: a request for a long call from a stranger tends to get ignored, while a short question gets answered. That is anecdotal, so test it with your own list.

Sending practicalities

- Send from a real address on your own domain. Use your real name and a signature with your business name and postal address or the identification required where you operate.
- Send in small batches, 10 to 20 a day, and personalise each one.
- Keep a record of everyone who asks you to stop, and never contact them again.
- Do not hide behind a no reply address, fake "Re:" subject lines or false familiarity.

Eight cold email templates

07. Trigger based opener

When to use: you found a real, recent event (hire, launch, funding, new service page).

Instructions: State the trigger in the first line. Connect it to one problem you solve. Ask a yes or no question.

```
Subject: Your new Bath office

Hi Ellis,

I saw Ridgeline opened a second office in Bath last month.
Studios that add a location often find project billing gets
harder to track across sites.

I help small studios set up stage billing so the director
sees profit per project in one report. Is that something you
are looking at this quarter?

Tom Reed, Reed Books, [postal address]
Reply "stop" and I will not write again.
```

08. Observation about a visible problem

When to use: you can see a specific, fixable issue (a broken form, slow page, unclear pricing page).

Instructions: Describe what you saw, say how you saw it, and offer to explain. Never exaggerate the damage.

```
Subject: Contact form on your services page

Hi Claire,

When I tried your contact form on the services page this
morning, it showed an error after I pressed send (Chrome on
desktop). You may already know.

I fix small website issues like this for studios, and can send
you the steps I took to reproduce it. Want me to send them?

Jo Martin, Martin Web Support
```

09. Mini audit offer

When to use: you can give a small piece of value in under 30 minutes.

Instructions: Offer a specific, bounded audit. Say what they get and that there is no obligation. Only offer what you will deliver.

```
Subject: A 10 point check of your booking page

Hi Dev,

I help physiotherapy clinics get more booking requests from
their existing website traffic. I would be glad to review
your booking page and send a 10 point list of fixes, free,
no obligation.

Should I send it to this address?

Aisha Khan, Clinic Growth Notes
```

O10. Short case note

When to use: you have a relevant, true result to share.

Instructions: Describe a similar client in one sentence, the result in one sentence, then the question. Label fictional examples as examples in your own materials.

```
Subject: Quote follow up at small builders

Hi Greg,

A 6 person building firm I worked with answered quotes in
five days on average. After we set up a quote template and a
two day reply rule, the average fell to two days (their own
tracking, over one quarter).

Do your quotes ever wait longer than you would like?

Lena Ortiz, Ortiz Operations
```

O11. Permission question

When to use: you are unsure the person owns the problem.

Instructions: Ask who is the right person, in one line. This lowers risk for the recipient.

```
Subject: Who handles event bookings at Harbour Hotel?

Hi Rosa,

I help hotels tidy up how corporate event enquiries are
handled. Are you the right person to ask about that, or
should I write to someone else?

Thanks for your time,
Mei Chen, Event Desk Support
```

O12. Partner or agency to agency note

When to use: you want to subcontract or refer work with a complementary firm.

Instructions: Say what you do that they do not, how the arrangement could work, and how you protect their client relationship.

```
Subject: Overflow design help for your web projects

Hi Karim,

Your portfolio is strong on web builds. I am a UX designer who
works as a white label partner for small agencies on a project
basis, and I do not contact your clients directly.

Would it be useful to have someone on call for overflow work?
I can send two sample files.

Jade Lowe, Lowe UX
```

O13. Genuine mention of a shared connection

When to use: you really do share a contact, and they have said it is fine to mention them.

Instructions: Get permission before using the name. Never imply an endorsement that was not given.

```
Subject: Marcus Bell suggested I write

Hi Ellis,

Marcus Bell suggested I get in touch (he said I could use his
name). I helped his studio fix late invoices, and he thought
you might be dealing with something similar.

Open to a short note on how it worked?

Tom Reed
```

O14. Hiring signal opener

When to use: the company posted a job that you could cover as a service or reduce the need for.

Instructions: Mention the ad, suggest an alternative or a bridge, and make the ask low risk. Do not mock the job.

```
Subject: Your open bookkeeper role

Hi Hana,

I saw Northgate Studio is hiring a part time bookkeeper. Until
you find the right person, I could cover month end on a fixed
monthly fee so books do not fall behind.

Would a short bridge arrangement help?

Tom Reed
```

Handling replies

- **Yes:** reply within the hour with two time options.
- **Not now:** thank them, ask when to follow up, and log the date.
- **Wrong person:** ask for the right contact.
- **Stop:** confirm that you will not write again, add them to your do not contact list, and do so.

Common mistakes and fixes

Mistake: Writing about yourself for four paragraphs.
Fix: One line about you, the rest about them.

Mistake: Template language such as "I hope this finds you well".
Fix: Replace with a first line that could only be sent to this person.

Mistake: Judging a template after five sends.
Fix: Judge after at least 30 sends of the same version.

CHAPTER 8

LinkedIn outreach

What LinkedIn is good for

LinkedIn lets you see roles, shared connections and public activity, so it suits relationship led outreach to named buyers. It is also a place with strict rules. LinkedIn's help pages state that it does not allow third party software or browser extensions that scrape, change the appearance of, or automate activity on the site, and that using such tools breaches the User Agreement and can lead to account restriction. This book therefore recommends manual outreach only. Send messages yourself, one at a time, in your own words.

A sensible manual routine

1. Optimise your headline: buyer, problem, result.
2. Spend 10 minutes a day on activity: comment usefully on three posts from your target buyers.
3. Send 5 to 10 personalised connection requests a day, no more than you can write properly.
4. When someone accepts, thank them and wait. Do not pitch in the first message after accept.
5. Move interested people to email or a call.

Six LinkedIn templates

O15. Connection note

When to use: first contact with a relevant person.

Instructions: Keep it under 200 characters, mention a real connection point, and make no pitch. Check the current character limit on your account.

```
Hi Ellis, I enjoyed your post on running a studio across two
sites. I work with small studios on billing. Happy to connect.
```

O16. Follow up after connection accepted

When to use: 1 to 2 days after acceptance.

Instructions: Thank them and ask a question related to their work. Do not attach a pitch.

```
Thanks for connecting, Ellis. Quick question out of curiosity:
with the Bath office open, how are you tracking profit per
project? No agenda, I am collecting how studios handle this.
```

O17. Comment to message bridge

When to use: a person engaged with your comment or you with theirs.

Instructions: Refer to the exact comment. Offer something relevant and wait for their interest.

```
Hi Neha, your comment on stage billing made me think of a one
page checklist I use with studios. Would you like me to send
it? Takes a minute to read.
```

O18. Post event note

When to use: after a webinar or online event where you both took part.

Instructions: Refer to something they said; do not mass message attendees.

```
Hi Daniel, your question about client deposits in today's
webinar was a good one. I wrote a short note on how some
studios handle deposits. Want me to share it?
```

O19. Reply to a buyer signal post

When to use: the prospect posted that they are looking for help with your type of work.

Instructions: Reply publicly first, briefly. Send a private message only if invited or if it adds value.

```
Hi Anika, saw your post asking for help with onboarding
emails. I do exactly this for software start ups. Happy to
share two sample sequences if useful. Should I send them here?
```

O20. Move to a call, politely

When to use: after at least two friendly exchanges and a clear need.

Instructions: Offer the call as an option and state the time cost.

```
Ellis, it sounds like profit by project is the open question.
I can show you a one page report layout in 20 minutes if that
would help. If it is easier, I can send it in writing instead.
```

What not to do on LinkedIn

- Do not use automation tools, scraping tools or bots, even those that claim to be safe.

- Do not send identical messages to hundreds of people.
- Do not pitch in connection requests or immediately after acceptance.
- Do not create fake profiles or fake engagement.
- Do not add people to a mailing list without asking.

Common mistakes and fixes

Mistake: Long pitches in the first message.
Fix: Shorten; make the first two messages about them.

Mistake: Sending 100 requests in a day.
Fix: Send fewer and write properly; volume limits are also set by LinkedIn.

Mistake: Neglecting your profile.
Fix: Each message sends people to your profile; make it state your offer.

CHAPTER 9

Content driven lead generation

What it can and cannot do

Content lets buyers find and judge you before talking to you. It is slower than outreach and compounds over time. Treat it as a second engine started alongside outreach, not a replacement for it.

Three kinds of content that attract buyers

1. **Problem content:** names a problem in the buyer's words and explains causes.
2. **Proof content:** shows how you work and what changed for a client (with consent).
3. **Process content:** teaches a method buyers could try themselves; it shows competence and builds trust.

A weekly rhythm that is possible alongside client work

Day	Task	Time
Mon	Note one question from a client or prospect	10 min
Tue	Write a 150 to 250 word post answering it	30 min
Wed	Publish and comment on 3 buyer posts	20 min
Thu	Reply to all comments	10 min

Day	Task	Time
Fri	Update one reusable piece (guide, checklist)	30 min

A reusable post structure

```
Line 1: A specific problem a buyer recognises.
Lines 2 to 5: Why it happens (two or three causes).
Lines 6 to 9: A method they can apply (steps).
Last line: An invitation to ask questions.
```

Filled example (fictional)

```
Why do invoices go out late at small studios?

Usually not laziness. Three causes I see often:
1. Billing is tied to project end, not stages.
2. Nobody owns invoice day.
3. Time data lives in three places.

Try this: list your stages, give each a share of the fee,
and pick one weekday as invoice day.

Questions about stage billing? Ask below.
```

Lead magnets with consent

A lead magnet is a useful document in exchange for an email address. If you collect addresses, say plainly what you will send and how to unsubscribe, store them safely, and send only what you promised. Under EU data protection law, personal data must be processed lawfully, fairly and transparently, for specified purposes, and kept no longer than necessary (European Commission, accessed 2026-11-07).

Turning content attention into conversations

- Reply to every comment within a day.
- When someone shows a clear need in a comment or message, offer a call; do not push.

- Keep a list of people who engage often. They are warm leads for Chapter 6 outreach.

Common mistakes and fixes

Mistake: Posting about trends rather than buyer problems.
Fix: Every post answers one real question from a buyer.

Mistake: Posting for two weeks, then stopping.
Fix: Use a smaller rhythm (one post a week) that you can keep for six months.

Mistake: No call to action.
Fix: End with a clear, low pressure next step.

CHAPTER 10

Discovery calls

Purpose

A discovery call is a conversation to decide whether there is a real problem, a real budget and a fit. It is not a pitch. You are collecting the information needed to qualify (Chapter 11) and to write a proposal (Chapter 12). The person who asks the best questions usually earns the right to propose.

Structure of a 30 minute call

Minutes	Part	Goal
0 to 3	Open	State purpose, time, and how it will end
3 to 15	Situation and problem	Understand what is happening and why now
15 to 22	Impact and past attempts	Cost of the problem; what has failed
22 to 27	Decision and budget	Who decides, when, what range
27 to 30	Next step	Agree a dated action

Opening line

> `Thanks for making time. I have 30 minutes blocked. I would like to understand what is going on, tell you honestly whether I can help, and agree a next step either way. Is that okay?`

Rules that make calls useful

- Talk less than 40% of the time.
- Write the buyer's own words down; use them in the proposal.
- Ask "what else?" before moving on.
- Ask about budget plainly and early enough to avoid wasting both sides' time.
- End with a dated next step, such as "I will send the proposal on Thursday and we speak Monday at 10."

Ten scripts by situation

Each script is a question set. The example shows the questions filled in for a fictional business, Reed Books, a bookkeeping practice for small studios. Adapt the wording to your trade.

C1. Inbound lead (they contacted you)

When to use: a form submission or email asking for help.

Instructions: Confirm what prompted the enquiry, then follow the structure. Do not assume their stated request is the real problem.

```
1. What made you reach out this week?
2. What happens today when an invoice needs to go out?
3. What is the effect when invoices are late?
4. What have you tried, and what happened?
5. If this were solved by month end, what changes for you?
6. Who else is involved in a decision like this?
7. Do you have a budget range in mind?
8. When would you like this running?
Close: "I will send a written proposal by Thursday."
```

C2. Referral call

When to use: someone you know introduced you.

Instructions: Thank the referrer, check what they told the prospect, and do not rely on borrowed trust.

```
1. Marcus mentioned you are opening a second office. How is
   that going?
2. What did he tell you about what I did for him?
3. What is different about your situation?
4. Where do you feel the most friction today?
5. What would a good outcome look like in three months?
6. Who else will weigh in?
7. What range have you considered?
Close: "Shall I send a short proposal and a reference you can
call?" (only if the reference has agreed)
```

C3. Cold reply call

When to use: someone replied to cold outreach and agreed to talk.

Instructions: They said yes to a short chat, not to a pitch. Re-state why you wrote, then ask more than you tell.

```
1. You replied to my note about project billing. What stood out?
2. How are you tracking profit by project right now?
3. How long does month end take?
4. Is this a priority this quarter or a someday item?
5. What would make it urgent?
6. Who would sign off on a fix?
7. Is it worth a more detailed look?
Close: "Let me send three questions in writing so I can come
back with a concrete suggestion."
```

C4. Price first buyer

When to use: the first question is "how much do you charge?"

Instructions: Give a range honestly if you have one, then ask what they are comparing against. Price without context invites a race to the bottom, but hiding price wastes time.

```
1. Happy to talk price. Typical projects like this range from
   [your range], depending on scope. Does that sit in the
   right area?
2. What are you comparing this with?
3. What does the cheaper option not cover that you need?
```

```
4. What is the cost of the problem staying as is?
5. What matters most: cost, speed, or low risk?
6. What budget did you set aside?
7. Shall I scope the lowest sensible option first?
Close: "I will send two options with different scope."
```

C5. Existing client expansion

When to use: a current client may need additional work.

Instructions: Review results first. Ask what changed, then identify the next constraint.

```
1. How is the monthly report working for you?
2. What decisions has it helped you make?
3. What is still manual or awkward?
4. What is changing in the business next quarter?
5. Who else in the firm feels the same pain?
6. If we added [new service], what would that unlock?
7. What would make it a priority?
Close: "I will outline a small first step and you can decide."
```

C6. Networking contact

When to use: you met at an event and agreed to a catch up.

Instructions: This is relationship building first. Be curious about their business, offer something useful, and only then move to need.

```
1. How has the year been in your business?
2. What are you focused on most right now?
3. What is slowing you down?
4. Who are your best customers, and how do you find more?
5. How can I be useful to you?
6. Do you know people who deal with [problem]?
Close: "I will send the article we talked about and keep you
in mind."
```

C7. Multiple decision makers

When to use: more than one person must agree.

Instructions: Ask each person what success looks like to them. Request that all decision makers join the proposal review.

```
1. Who is involved in this decision?
2. What does each person need to see?
3. Who could say no, and why?
4. What happened with the last project like this?
5. What approvals are needed, and how long do they take?
6. Can everyone join a 20 minute review of the proposal?
Close: "I will tailor the proposal to each person's concern."
```

C8. Burned by a previous provider

When to use: the buyer mentions a bad past experience.

Instructions: Do not criticise the other provider. Find out exactly what went wrong and how you will prevent it.

```
1. What happened last time?
2. At what point did you notice it was going wrong?
3. What should have been done differently?
4. What would you need to see to trust a new provider?
5. How could we reduce the risk (smaller first phase, weekly
   check ins, fixed scope)?
6. What does "done" look like for you?
Close: "Let me propose a smaller first phase so you can judge
the work before committing further."
```

C9. Early stage "just exploring"

When to use: the buyer has little urgency and no budget yet.

Instructions: Help them clarify and do not push. Qualify the timeline honestly and schedule a future check in.

```
1. What got you looking at this?
2. What would need to happen for this to become a priority?
3. By when would you want a decision?
4. What is the budget process?
5. What would help you decide?
```

```
6. Would a short written overview help?
Close: "I will send the overview and check in on [date]."
```

C10. Reactivated past client

When to use: someone you worked with before returns.

Instructions: Recap the previous result, then ask what changed. Update scope and price based on new facts.

```
1. Good to hear from you. What changed since we last worked
   together?
2. How did last time's work hold up?
3. What is the new priority?
4. Who is involved this time?
5. What constraints do you have on time and budget?
6. Should we start from the previous setup or reconsider it?
Close: "I will send an updated scope and price this week."
```

After the call

Within one hour: update the CRM, write a three line summary in the buyer's own words, score using the worksheet in Chapter 11, and send a thank you with the agreed next step. Send the summary to the buyer; it confirms understanding and prevents drift.

```
Subject: Summary of today's call

Hi Ellis, thanks for your time. What I heard:
- Invoices go out up to 3 weeks late.
- Cash flow is tight at month end.
- You want this running before the year end.
Next step: I will send a proposal by Thursday.
Please tell me if I missed anything.
```

Common mistakes and fixes

Mistake: Pitching in the first ten minutes.
Fix: Do not describe your service until you have summarised their problem back to them and they agreed.

Mistake: Skipping budget.
Fix: Ask once, plainly. If they refuse to answer, offer ranges: "Are we closer to A, B or C?"

Mistake: No next step.
Fix: Do not hang up without a dated action for both sides.

CHAPTER 11

Client qualification

Why qualify

Not every lead is a good client. Working with a poor fit costs time, margin and attention. Qualification is a structured judgement made after learning enough, and it protects both sides. You can say no politely and refer them elsewhere.

Qualification worksheet

Score each factor from 0 to 2 (0 weak, 1 partial, 2 strong). Maximum 20.

```
CLIENT QUALIFICATION WORKSHEET

Lead: _______  Date: _______

1. Problem is real and named by them            (0-2)
2. Cost of the problem is clear                 (0-2)
3. Urgency: a reason to act within 90 days      (0-2)
4. Budget: range stated or confirmed            (0-2)
5. Authority: decision maker is on the call     (0-2)
6. Fit: matches my ICP and service              (0-2)
7. Scope is clear and realistic                 (0-2)
8. Communication: responsive, respectful        (0-2)
9. Payment: terms accepted in principle         (0-2)
10. Access: can provide inputs when needed      (0-2)

Total: ___ / 20
```

How to read the score

Score	Action
16 to 20	Send a proposal within 48 hours
11 to 15	Fix the weak factors first (ask, clarify, involve the decision maker)
6 to 10	Nurture; send resources; check in later
0 to 5	Politely decline and refer

Two rules override the total. Any score of 0 on Authority or Budget means you cannot send a final proposal yet. A score of 0 on Communication or Payment means you pause, because these predict trouble later.

These cut offs are a decision aid I propose, not a validated statistical model. Adjust them after you review 20 of your own deals.

Worked example (fictional)

Lead: Ridgeline Studio, director Ellis Wong.

Factor	Score	Reason
Problem	2	"Invoices wait weeks"
Cost	1	Cash flow mentioned, not quantified
Urgency	2	Year end in 8 weeks
Budget	1	Gave a monthly figure, not total
Authority	2	Ellis signs
Fit	2	In ICP
Scope	1	Unsure about second office
Communication	2	Replied same day
Payment	1	Wants quarterly invoicing
Access	2	Will share data on day one

Total 16. Action: send a proposal within 48 hours. Open items before sending: quantify cost, confirm scope for the second office, agree payment terms.

Red flags

- Refuses to say who decides.
- Asks for free sample work on their real project.
- Disputes price before knowing scope.
- Talks about previous providers with contempt and no self reflection.
- Wants a start date before agreeing terms.
- Cannot describe what success looks like.

A red flag is a question, not a verdict. Ask about it directly and judge the answer.

Saying no well

```
Hi Ellis, thank you for the detail. After thinking it
through, I am not the right fit for this one because
[honest reason, e.g. the scope needs a specialist in
multi site tax]. I can recommend [name] who does that. If
things change, I am happy to talk again.
```

Common mistakes and fixes

Mistake: Qualifying only on whether they can pay.
Fix: Use all ten factors; payment is one.

Mistake: Ignoring a low score because you need work.
Fix: Decide the minimum score in advance, when you are calm.

Mistake: Not updating the score.
Fix: Rescore after the proposal meeting.

CHAPTER 12

Proposals and closing

What a proposal is for

A proposal confirms what you heard, shows how you will solve it, states the price and terms, and makes the next step easy. If the call went well, nothing in the proposal should surprise the buyer. Forum discussions among freelancers repeatedly mention proposals that sit unopened in an inbox after a good call. The practical fix is to present the proposal live, or at least agree a date to discuss it, rather than emailing a document and hoping.

Section by section structure (use for all frameworks)

1. **Summary of the situation** in the buyer's words.
2. **Goal and success measures.**
3. **Approach** in steps.
4. **Scope:** included and excluded.
5. **Timeline and milestones.**
6. **Investment:** price, payment schedule.
7. **Terms:** revisions, change requests, ownership, cancellation.
8. **Next steps:** what happens if they say yes.

Five proposal frameworks

P1. One page proposal

When to use: small projects, quick decisions.

Instructions: Keep it to one page; present in the call or follow with a short call.

```
Ridgeline Studio, billing setup. Prepared 12 Nov.

Situation: Invoices go out up to 3 weeks late; month end
takes a day for the director.
Goal: Invoices out within 5 days of a stage signing; one
profit report per project.
Approach: 1) Map stages. 2) Configure software. 3) Build the
report. 4) Train staff.
Included: setup, template, one training session, 30 days of
support. Not included: tax advice, data cleanup older than
12 months.
Timeline: 3 weeks from start date.
Investment: 1,800 fixed. 50% on acceptance, 50% on delivery.
To start: reply "yes" and I will send the agreement.
```

P2. Three option proposal

When to use: the buyer is price sensitive or unsure about scope.

Instructions: Offer three levels. The middle one should be the one you want; the others make choice easy.

```
Option A, Essentials: Setup and report. 1,800.
Option B, Recommended: Setup, report, 3 months of monthly
 close with review call. 3,600.
Option C, Full: Option B plus quarterly planning and
 year end preparation. 5,400.
All options: 3 week setup. Payment: 50% on acceptance,
balance on delivery (monthly services billed monthly).
Differences: B adds ongoing close; C adds planning.
```

P3. Problem, solution, proof proposal

When to use: the buyer must convince others, so the logic needs to be clear.

Instructions: Lead with the problem and its cost, then the solution, then proof, then price.

```
Problem: Late invoices delay cash by about 3 weeks, and
reporting takes 8 hours a month.
Cost: At 8 hours at 60 an hour, 480 a month in time alone,
before cash flow effects (the director's own estimate).
Solution: Stage billing, a weekly invoice day, a project
profit report.
Proof: Two similar studios completed this setup (case notes
available on request).
Price: 1,800 setup, 600 a month for monthly close.
Decision needed by: 20 Nov to start before year end.
```

P4. Phased proposal with paid first step

When to use: high uncertainty, larger scope, or a nervous buyer.

Instructions: Price phase one as a standalone deliverable. The buyer decides on phase two with evidence.

```
Phase 1, Diagnostic (2 weeks): Review current billing,
deliver a findings report and plan. 900.
Phase 2, Build (3 weeks): Implement the plan. Price confirmed
after Phase 1, estimated 1,800 to 2,400.
Phase 3, Run (monthly): 600 a month, 3 month minimum.
You may stop after any phase. Phase 1 fee is credited
against Phase 2 if you continue within 30 days.
```

P5. Retainer proposal

When to use: ongoing work with a steady, recurring need.

Instructions: Define hours or deliverables per month, response times, reporting and how to end it.

```
Monthly retainer: bookkeeping and reporting
Includes: month end close, project profit report, one 45 minute
review call, email questions answered within 2 working days.
Not included: tax filings, payroll.
Fee: 600 a month, invoiced on the 1st, payable in 14 days.
Term: 3 months, then rolling with 30 days notice.
Review: quarterly, to adjust scope and fee.
```

Closing the conversation

Present the proposal live where possible. Walk through the situation, the approach and the price, then ask a direct question.

```
Does this match what you need? Is there anything you would
want changed before we go ahead? If not, shall we start on
Monday 1 December?
```

Silence after a proposal is usually not a no; it is often inertia. Chapter 14 covers follow up.

Agreement and start

Once they accept: send a short agreement (a lawyer can review your standard template), an invoice for the deposit, and an onboarding checklist. Clarity at the start prevents disputes later. This book does not provide contract wording; get a template reviewed for your jurisdiction.

Common mistakes and fixes

Mistake: Sending a long document by email after the call.
Fix: Offer a 20 minute walkthrough, or send a one page version.

Mistake: Hiding the price at the end.
Fix: State it plainly, tied to scope and options.

Mistake: No deadline or next step.
Fix: Say what happens on acceptance and by when you hold the start slot.

CHAPTER 13

Pricing and negotiation

Four pricing models

Model	You charge for	Works best when	Main risk
Hourly	Time spent	Scope is unclear or changes	Rewards slowness, caps income at hours worked
Project	A defined deliverable	Scope is clear	Underestimating effort
Value	A share of the benefit	Result is measurable and big	Hard to prove; needs trust
Retainer	Ongoing availability or output	Recurring need	Scope creep inside the monthly fee

This book does not state market rates. They vary by country, niche, experience and demand, and any figure I gave would be unsourced. Use your own costs and your own quotes. All numbers below are arithmetic examples in an unnamed currency, and I ran them in a script to confirm them.

Step 1: find your minimum hourly rate

Start from the income you need, add business costs, and divide by hours you can actually bill.

```
Income target (after business costs):  60,000
Business costs per year:               12,000
Weeks worked per year:                 46
Billable hours per week:               25
Billable hours per year:               46 x 25 = 1,150
Minimum rate: (60,000 + 12,000) / 1,150 = 62.61
```

The 25 billable hours assume the rest of the week goes to acquisition, admin and learning, which is why Chapter 15 gives it a budget. If you bill 35 hours a week the rate falls; if you bill 15 it rises. This is a floor, not a price. Tax, benefits and savings depend on your country and are not modelled here.

Hourly

Rate times hours. Use it when scope is truly unknown, and cap it with an estimate: "up to 20 hours, I will tell you at 15."

Project

Estimate hours, multiply by your floor, add a buffer for uncertainty.

```
Estimated hours:        40
Base: 40 x 62.61 =      2,504.35
Buffer 20%:             2,504.35 x 1.20 = 3,005.22
Quoted (rounded):       3,000
```

Check against reality: if the job takes 52 hours, you earned 3,000 / 52 = 57.69 per hour, below your floor, while the client paid 3,000 for a result. At 52 hours your floor would have required 52 x 62.61 = 3,255.65. Track actual hours on every project to improve the next estimate. A project fee also lets you gain if you work faster.

Value pricing

Price against the benefit the client expects, if you can credibly estimate it with them.

```
Client expects extra yearly profit:   30,000 (their estimate)
Fee at 10% of that:                   3,000
Fee at 15% of that:                   4,500
```

Use the buyer's own estimate, not yours, and write the assumption into the proposal. Never promise the benefit. A value based fee only makes sense when your work plausibly contributes and the client accepts the logic. Treat percentages as a negotiation starting point, not a rule.

Retainer

```
Monthly hours included:      10
Hours x floor:               10 x 62.61 = 626.09
Availability premium 15%:    626.09 x 1.15 = 720.00
Monthly fee:                 720
```

The premium pays for reserved capacity and for the client's guaranteed access. A retainer gives you predictable income and gives the client priority; define what is included and what is billed extra.

Present a price

1. State the price once, clearly, after confirming scope.
2. Tie it to an outcome and a timeline, not to hours.
3. Offer options so the choice is which, not whether.
4. Stay quiet after you say it.

Negotiation

Negotiation is trading, not conceding. When a buyer asks for a discount, change the scope or the terms in exchange.

```
Request: "Can you do it for 2,700 instead of 3,000?"
Reply: "I can do 2,700 if we remove the training session
and handle the revisions in one round. Would that work?"
```

A discount of 10% on 3,000 is 300. At your floor of 62.61, that is 300 / 62.61 = 4.79 hours of work given away. Expressing a discount in hours makes its real cost clear.

Other tradeable items: payment up front, a longer commitment, a case study right, a faster decision date, a referral. Do not trade price for nothing.

Handling "too expensive"

- Ask: "Too expensive compared to what?"
- Revisit the cost of the problem the buyer described.
- Offer a smaller first phase (P4 in Chapter 12).
- Accept that some buyers will not pay your price. That is acceptable.

Payment terms

State them in the proposal: deposit, schedule, due date, late fees only if your jurisdiction and agreement allow. Many freelancers take a deposit before work begins. Get a template reviewed for your location.

Common mistakes and fixes

Mistake: Setting prices from competitors' public rates.
Fix: Start from your costs and outcomes; use competitors only as context.

Mistake: Discounting without exchange.
Fix: Every price drop buys something: scope, speed, commitment or payment terms.

Mistake: Fixed price with no change process.
Fix: Write what counts as a change and how it is priced.

CHAPTER 14

Follow up systems

Why follow up

People are busy. A single message is easy to miss, and one reason forum discussions give for non replies is that the reply comes after a nudge, not after the first note. That is anecdotal; your own tracking is the proof. Follow up is not nagging if each message adds something and has an end.

Follow up rules

1. Every lead has a next action and a date. Nothing sits without both.
2. Cold outreach: at most four touches (first message plus three), spaced 3 to 7 days apart, then stop and note the date. Do not send more.
3. Each follow up adds something new: a fact, a resource, a clearer question.
4. Opt outs stop the sequence immediately and permanently.
5. After a proposal, follow up on a schedule: day 2, day 7, day 14.
6. A clear "no" is a result. Thank them and close the record.

Ten follow up templates

F1. First gentle nudge

When to use: 3 to 4 days after a cold email with no reply.

Instructions: Keep it to two lines and restate the question.

```
Subject: Re: Your new Bath office

Hi Ellis, a quick nudge in case this got buried. Is project
billing something you are looking at this quarter?

Tom
```

F2. Value add follow up

When to use: 7 days after the first message.

Instructions: Give something useful that needs no reply.

```
Hi Ellis, I put together a one page checklist for stage
billing in studios. It is attached; take it whether or not we
talk. If you want to go through it together, say so.

Tom
```

F3. Breakup message

When to use: after three touches without reply.

Instructions: Close the loop politely and leave the door open.

```
Hi Ellis, I will assume the timing is not right and stop
writing. If invoice delays become a priority, you are welcome
to contact me. Best wishes with the Bath office.

Tom
```

F4. After call, before proposal

When to use: within an hour of a discovery call.

Instructions: Summarise in their words and confirm the next step.

```
Hi Ellis, thank you for today. What I heard: invoices wait up
to three weeks, the year end is in eight weeks, and you want
one profit report per project. I will send the proposal by
Thursday 5 pm. Please correct anything I missed.

Tom
```

F5. Two days after proposal

When to use: day 2 after sending.

Instructions: Ask a question that moves things forward, not "just checking in".

```
Hi Ellis, did the proposal answer your questions? If useful, I
can walk you through it in 15 minutes this week. Tuesday or
Wednesday?

Tom
```

F6. Seven days after proposal

When to use: day 7 with no reply.

Instructions: Offer to adjust and ask what is blocking.

```
Hi Ellis, I know year end is busy. If price or scope is
the sticking point, I can adjust the scope to fit. What
would help you decide?

Tom
```

F7. Revive a silent proposal

When to use: 14 days or more of silence.

Instructions: Give a reason to act and an easy way to decline.

```
Hi Ellis, I can hold the 1 December start date until Friday.
After that my next slot is in January. A quick "yes", "not
```

```
now" or "no" is fine, so I can plan.

Tom
```

F8. Verbal yes, awaiting signature

When to use: the buyer agreed verbally but has not signed.

Instructions: Make the next step simple and remove obstacles.

```
Hi Ellis, great news that we are going ahead. To hold the
start date I need the signed agreement and the deposit
invoice paid by Wednesday. Is anything holding that up?

Tom
```

F9. After a no

When to use: the buyer declined.

Instructions: Thank them, ask one learning question, and keep the relationship.

```
Hi Ellis, thank you for letting me know. If you are willing,
what was the main reason (price, timing, fit)? It helps me
improve. Good luck with the year end.

Tom
```

F10. Scheduled resurface after "not now"

When to use: on the date the buyer asked you to return.

Instructions: Remind them of the earlier conversation and ask if the situation changed.

```
Hi Ellis, in September you said to check back after the Bath
office opened. Is project billing back on the agenda?
```

> Tom

Lead tracking system

Stages

Stage	Definition	Exit rule
New	Qualified on ICP, not contacted	First message sent
Contacted	First message sent	Reply, or 4 touches done
Replied	They responded	Call booked, or declined
Call booked	Date set	Call held or no show
Call held	Discovery done	Scored; proposal sent or declined
Proposal sent	Proposal delivered	Won, lost or nurture
Won	Signed and paid deposit	Move to client delivery
Lost	Declined or no response after follow up	Record reason
Nurture	Not now; dated follow up	Revisit on date

Columns

Name, company, role, source, trigger, stage, date contacted, date replied, date call held, date proposal sent, date won, deal value, next action, next action date, fit score, notes. Appendix B gives the spreadsheet layout.

Rules

- Update the sheet the same day.
- No lead without a next action date.
- A lead untouched for 14 days is flagged: act or close.
- Record a reason for every loss.

- Keep a do not contact list, and check every new list against it.

Weekly review routine (30 minutes, Friday)

1. Count contacts, replies, calls, proposals and wins this week.
2. List overdue next actions and clear them.
3. Review lost deals for reasons.
4. Pick the weakest conversion step and change one thing.
5. Plan next week's volume.

Common mistakes and fixes

Mistake: Following up with "just checking in".
Fix: Add something new or ask a specific question.

Mistake: No end to the sequence.
Fix: Four touches, then a dated pause.

Mistake: Following up only on proposals.
Fix: Track every stage; the leak is often earlier.

CHAPTER 15

Building repeatable client acquisition processes

A weekly rhythm

Consistency matters more than intensity. A repeatable week looks like this (adapt to your hours):

Day	Block	Time
Monday	Research and add 10 leads	45 min
Tuesday	Send 10 personal messages	45 min
Wednesday	Content post and community replies	40 min
Thursday	Follow ups and calls	60 min
Friday	Proposals, CRM and weekly review	45 min

That is about 3 hours 55 minutes a week, roughly 47 minutes a day over five days. Check this against the pricing model: at 25 billable hours a week plus under 5 for acquisition, the week fits into 30 hours (arithmetic: 25 + 3.9 = 28.9).

Measure four numbers

1. Contacts per week.
2. Reply rate (replies / contacts).
3. Calls held per week.
4. Win rate (won / proposals).

Change one variable at a time. If replies are low, change the first line. If calls are few, change the ask. If proposals are lost, change qualification or pricing.

30 day roadmap

Time budget: about 60 minutes a day, five days a week, plus a 30 minute review each Friday.

Week 1: foundation

Day	Task
1	Fill in the ICP worksheet (Chapter 3)
2	Write your offer statement (Chapter 4)
3	Build one proof item (Chapter 5)
4	List 30 warm contacts
5	Set up the CRM sheet (Appendix B) and review

Week 2: warm outreach

Day	Task
6	Send 5 messages from O1, O4, O6
7	Ask 3 contacts for introductions (O2)
8	Add 15 researched leads
9	Follow up on week 1 messages
10	Book calls; weekly review

Week 3: cold outreach

Day	Task
11	Send 10 emails (O7 to O14), with opt out
12	Send 5 LinkedIn notes by hand (O15)
13	Publish one post (Chapter 9)

Day	Task
14	Follow ups F1, F2
15	Hold calls; score each; weekly review

Week 4: calls and proposals

Day	Task
16	Send 10 more messages
17	Hold discovery calls using C1 to C10
18	Send proposals to qualified leads
19	Follow up on proposals (F5, F6)
20	Full review: conversion rates, weak step, plan month 2

Days 21 to 30 repeat weeks 3 and 4 with changes based on the review. I cannot say how many clients this will produce; that depends on your niche, offer and market. What the 30 days give you is a tested process and real numbers.

Systemise

- Save templates in a folder; improve the best performer.
- Create a checklist for each stage.
- Block calendar time for acquisition and treat it as client work.
- Review the system every quarter: drop what does not work.

Common mistakes and fixes

Mistake: Stopping acquisition when you are busy.
Fix: Keep a minimum (five messages a week).

Mistake: Changing everything at once.
Fix: One change per two weeks.

Mistake: No review.
Fix: The Friday review is the system.

Conclusion

A client acquisition system is a small set of repeated habits: a clear target, an honest offer, proof, contact with real people, good conversations, clear proposals, fair prices and follow up. None of it needs cleverness. It needs a calendar, a spreadsheet and the discipline to look at the numbers.

Do this next:

- [ ] Fill in the ICP worksheet today.
- [ ] Write your offer statement.
- [ ] List 30 warm contacts and send five messages this week.
- [ ] Set up the CRM sheet from Appendix B.
- [ ] Read Appendix A before sending any cold message.
- [ ] Book your first Friday review in your calendar.

After 30 days, compare your own conversion rates with the illustration in Chapter 1, not as a target but as a method. Fix the weakest step, repeat, and keep improving.

Appendix A. Ethics, consent, anti spam rules and platform rules

This appendix is general information, not legal advice. Rules on marketing messages and personal data differ by country, by the type of recipient (company or individual) and by channel. If you contact people in several countries, check each one or ask a qualified adviser.

Principles for honest outreach

- Say who you are and why you are writing.
- Never use a false name, a fake "Re:" subject line, or a made up connection.
- Make claims you can prove. Label examples as examples.
- Write to people who plausibly have the problem, not to everyone.
- Make it easy to say no, and respect it immediately.
- Collect and keep only the personal data you need, and delete it when you no longer need it.

United States: CAN-SPAM

The US Federal Trade Commission's compliance guide for business (accessed 2026-11-07) says the law applies to commercial email, and that it makes no exception for business to business email. It lists these requirements:

- Header information must be accurate and identify the sender.
- Subject lines must not be deceptive.
- The message must be identified as an advertisement.
- The message must include a valid physical postal address.
- The message must tell recipients how to opt out of future email.
- Opt out requests must be honoured within 10 business days, and the opt out mechanism must work for at least 30 days after sending.
- You remain responsible for email sent on your behalf by another company.

The page states penalties of up to 53,088 US dollars per separate email in violation. Read the full guide at the FTC link in Appendix E. A practical footer for a cold email:

```
Tom Reed, Reed Books, 12 Example Road, Anytown, AB1 2CD.
If you would rather not hear from me, reply "stop" and I
will not write again.
```

European Union and United Kingdom

The European Commission's data protection page (accessed 2026-11-07) describes the General Data Protection Regulation as the EU's main data protection law. It covers any information relating to an identified or identifiable living individual, so a named business contact's email address is personal data. It says organisations must process personal data lawfully, fairly and transparently, for specified purposes, collect no more than needed, keep it only as long as necessary, keep it accurate and secure, and be accountable. Individuals have rights including to be informed, to access, correct and erase their data, to object, and to restrict processing. It applies to organisations in the EU and to organisations outside the EU that offer goods or services to people in the EU or monitor their behaviour. Small businesses must comply too, though some obligations can be lighter.

Separate rules govern electronic marketing messages in the EU and the UK. In the UK these are the Privacy and Electronic Communications Regulations (PECR), enforced by the Information Commissioner's Office (ICO). The ICO pages I tried to open (accessed 2026-11-07) returned an access error, so I cannot quote them. Search summaries of the ICO's business to business marketing guidance describe a difference between corporate subscribers (such as limited companies) and individual subscribers (such as sole traders and some partnerships), with stricter consent rules for individuals, and a recommendation to keep a suppression list of people who object. Treat that as a pointer, not a statement of the law. Read the current ICO guidance to PECR and direct marketing yourself before sending marketing email to anyone in the UK, and check the equivalent rules of each EU country before writing to EU recipients.

Platform rules: LinkedIn

I opened two LinkedIn help pages (accessed 2026-11-07): "Prohibited software and extensions" and "Automated activity on LinkedIn". They say LinkedIn does not allow third party software, including bots and browser extensions, that scrapes data, changes how the site looks or automates activity, and that using such tools is a violation of the User Agreement. LinkedIn warns that accounts can be restricted or closed and that tools may stop working without notice. This book therefore recommends only manual outreach on LinkedIn and does not recommend scraping or automation tools, including ones that advertise themselves as safe.

Other platforms have their own rules. Read them before you use the platform for outreach, and follow community rules in forums and groups.

Practical compliance checklist

- [ ] I identify myself truthfully in every message.

- [ ] I include a way to opt out and a postal address or business identification where required.
- [ ] I honour opt outs at once and keep a do not contact list.
- [ ] I know the rule for the country and type of recipient I am writing to.
- [ ] I store contact data securely and delete it when no longer needed.
- [ ] I do not use scraped or bought lists.
- [ ] I do not automate activity on platforms that forbid it.

Appendix B. CRM spreadsheet structure

A spreadsheet is enough for a solo practice. It works in Excel and Google Sheets. Create four sheets: Leads, Dashboard, Lists and DoNotContact.

Sheet 1: Leads

Row 1 holds headers. Data starts in row 2.

Col	Header	Notes
A	ID	L001, L002, ...
B	Name	Contact person
C	Company	
D	Role	
E	Source	Validation list (below)
F	Stage	Validation list (below)
G	Date contacted	Date format
H	Date replied	
I	Date call held	
J	Date proposal sent	
K	Date won	
L	Deal value	Number

Col	Header	Notes
M	Next action	Short text
N	Next action date	Date
O	Fit score	Whole number 0 to 20
P	Notes	

Example rows (fictional)

```
L001 | Priya Shah | Studio Arc  | Principal | Referral   | Won
  contacted 2026-09-01, replied 09-01, call 09-04,
  proposal 09-06, won 09-10 | 1800 | - | - | 17
L002 | Ellis Wong | Ridgeline   | Director  | Cold email |
Proposal sent
  contacted 2026-10-05, replied 10-07, call 10-12,
  proposal 10-14 | 3600 | Follow up F6 | 2026-10-21 | 16
L003 | Hana Ito   | Northgate   | Manager   | LinkedIn   |
Contacted
  contacted 2026-10-30 | 1200 | F1 nudge | 2026-11-03 | 11
```

Sheet 3: Lists (for data validation)

Put one list per column, with a header in row 1.

- **Column A, Stage:** New, Contacted, Replied, Call booked, Call held, Proposal sent, Won, Lost, Nurture.
- **Column B, Source:** Referral, Past client, Cold email, LinkedIn, Community, Event, Content, Inbound.
- **Column C, Loss reason:** Price, Timing, Fit, No response, Chose other, Other.

Data validation (both Excel and Google Sheets)

- **Stage (F2:F500):** list from range `=Lists!$A$2:$A$10`. In Excel: Data, Data Validation, Allow List. In Google Sheets: Data, Data validation, Dropdown from a range.

- **Source (E2:E500):** list from `=Lists!$B$2:$B$9`.
- **Fit score (O2:O500):** whole number between 0 and 20.
- **Date columns (G:K and N):** date validation, reject text.

Sheet 2: Dashboard

Labels in column A, formulas in column B. The formulas below use only functions that exist with the same name and argument order in Excel and Google Sheets: COUNT, COUNTIFS, SUMIFS, IFERROR and TODAY.

Cell	Label	Formula
B2	Contacted	`=COUNT(Leads!G2:G500)`
B3	Replied	`=COUNT(Leads!H2:H500)`
B4	Calls held	`=COUNT(Leads!I2:I500)`
B5	Proposals sent	`=COUNT(Leads!J2:J500)`
B6	Won	`=COUNT(Leads!K2:K500)`
B7	Reply rate	`=IFERROR(B3/B2,0)`
B8	Reply to call	`=IFERROR(B4/B3,0)`
B9	Call to proposal	`=IFERROR(B5/B4,0)`
B10	Proposal win rate	`=IFERROR(B6/B5,0)`
B11	Overall rate	`=IFERROR(B6/B2,0)`
B12	Value won	`=SUMIFS(Leads!L2:L500,Leads!F2:F500,"Won")`
B13	Overdue actions	see below
B14	Average deal	`=IFERROR(B12/B6,0)`
B15	Cold email reply rate	see below

Overdue actions (B13):

```
=COUNTIFS(Leads!N2:N500,"<"&TODAY(),
```

```
 Leads!F2:F500,"<>Won",Leads!F2:F500,"<>Lost")
```

Cold email reply rate (B15):

```
=IFERROR(COUNTIFS(Leads!E2:E500,"Cold email",
 Leads!H2:H500,"<>")/COUNTIFS(Leads!E2:E500,
 "Cold email",Leads!G2:G500,"<>"),0)
```

Enter each formula on one line. Format B7 to B11 and B15 as percentages. Counting dates rather than stages means that a lead that moves on still counts at every earlier step.

How I checked them: I built a test workbook with five invented leads, entered these formulas, recalculated it in LibreOffice (not in Excel or Google Sheets) and compared the results with hand counts: contacted 5, replied 3, calls 2, proposals 2, won 1, reply rate 0.6, overall 0.2, value won 3,000, overdue 1, cold email reply rate 0.667. All matched. Excel and Google Sheets use the same function names and argument order for these functions, but I did not run them there. Test them on a few rows before relying on them. The data validation settings were not tested.

Sheet 4: DoNotContact

Columns: name, email or profile, date asked to stop, channel. Check every new lead against this sheet before sending.

Rules

- One row per person. Update the same day.
- Every open lead has a next action and a date.
- Do not delete lost rows; filter them out. They are your data.

Appendix C. Templates index

Code	Name	Chapter
O1	Referral ask to a happy client	6
O2	Warm introduction request	6
O3	Forwardable introduction blurb	6
O4	Past client reactivation	6
O5	Community reply that offers help	6
O6	Event or meeting follow up	6
O7	Trigger based opener	7
O8	Observation about a visible problem	7
O9	Mini audit offer	7
O10	Short case note	7
O11	Permission question	7
O12	Partner or agency to agency note	7
O13	Genuine mention of a shared connection	7
O14	Hiring signal opener	7
O15	LinkedIn connection note	8
O16	Follow up after connection accepted	8
O17	Comment to message bridge	8
O18	Post event note	8

Code	Name	Chapter
O19	Reply to a buyer signal post	8
O20	Move to a call, politely	8
C1	Inbound lead call	10
C2	Referral call	10
C3	Cold reply call	10
C4	Price first buyer	10
C5	Existing client expansion	10
C6	Networking contact	10
C7	Multiple decision makers	10
C8	Burned by a previous provider	10
C9	Early stage "just exploring"	10
C10	Reactivated past client	10
P1	One page proposal	12
P2	Three option proposal	12
P3	Problem, solution, proof proposal	12
P4	Phased proposal with paid first step	12
P5	Retainer proposal	12
F1	First gentle nudge	14
F2	Value add follow up	14
F3	Breakup message	14
F4	After call, before proposal	14
F5	Two days after proposal	14
F6	Seven days after proposal	14
F7	Revive a silent proposal	14
F8	Verbal yes, awaiting signature	14
F9	After a no	14

Code	Name	Chapter
F10	Scheduled resurface after "not now"	14

Worksheets: ICP worksheet (Chapter 3), offer statement (Chapter 4), case note (Chapter 5), qualification worksheet (Chapter 11), pricing calculations (Chapter 13), lead tracking system (Chapter 14), CRM structure (Appendix B), 30 day roadmap (Chapter 15).

Appendix D. Glossary

Authority: the power to approve and pay for a purchase.

Breakup message: a final polite follow up that closes a sequence.

Buyer: the person who pays or approves the budget; may differ from the user.

CAN-SPAM: the United States law on commercial email.

Cold outreach: a first message to someone who has not asked to hear from you.

Conversion rate: the share of people who move from one pipeline stage to the next.

CRM: customer relationship management; here, a spreadsheet that tracks leads and next actions.

Discovery call: a conversation to understand a prospect's problem, budget and fit.

GDPR: the EU General Data Protection Regulation.

ICP: ideal customer profile; the written description of the best fit buyer.

Inbound lead: a prospect who contacted you first.

Lead: a named person at a business who fits your ICP and can be contacted honestly.

Lead magnet: a free resource offered in exchange for contact details.

Niche: a specific group of buyers sharing a problem you can solve.

Nurture: keeping contact with a lead who is not ready, on a dated schedule.

Offer: a specific result, scope, timeline and price structure for a defined buyer.

Opt out: a request to stop receiving messages.

Pipeline: the set of leads at each stage between first contact and a signed deal.

Productised service: a service sold with a fixed scope and price.

Proposal: a document or presentation that sets out the approach, scope, price and terms.

Qualification: judging whether a lead is a good fit before investing in a proposal.

Retainer: a recurring fee for ongoing work or availability.

Scope creep: work expanding beyond what was agreed without a change in price.

Trigger: an observable event that makes a problem urgent.

Value pricing: setting a fee relative to the benefit the client expects.

Appendix E. References and further reading

All pages below were opened on 2026-11-07 unless noted.

- Federal Trade Commission, CAN-SPAM Act: A Compliance Guide for Business. https://www.ftc.gov/business-guidance/resources/can-spam-act-compliance-guide-business (accessed 2026-11-07). Supports the CAN-SPAM requirements, the B2B statement and the penalty figure in Appendix A.
- European Commission, Data protection explained. https://commission.europa.eu/law/law-topic/data-protection/data-protection-explained_en (accessed 2026-11-07). Supports the description of GDPR scope, principles and individual rights.
- LinkedIn Help, Prohibited software and extensions. https://www.linkedin.com/help/linkedin/answer/a1341387 (accessed 2026-11-07). Supports the statement that LinkedIn prohibits bots and browser extensions that scrape or automate.
- LinkedIn Help, Automated activity on LinkedIn. https://www.linkedin.com/help/linkedin/answer/90586 (accessed 2026-11-07). Supports the same rule and the account restriction process.

Not opened: the UK ICO guidance pages (https://ico.org.uk) returned an access error on 2026-11-07. Readers should read the ICO's current PECR and direct marketing guidance directly.